

BEST OF BOTH



LEFT ON A HIGH:
General Secretary
Prakash Karat, with
the party top brass
on the opening day
of the 19th party
congress

■ By **M.G. Radhakrishnan** in Coimbatore

Alu leedu chulu leedu, koduku peeru Somalingam..(I have no wife, no house. But my son's name is Somalingam)". In a rare excursion into his mother tongue, CPI(M) Politburo member Sitaram Yechury quoted this Telugu proverb at the party's 19th congress to snipe at B.J.P. "They don't have any plans for the coming elections. But they have already announced their next prime minister," said Yechury in an obvious attempt to expose the

various contradictions and ironies that exist in CPI(M)'s main adversary. But by the time the meeting had drawn to a close in Coimbatore in Tamil Nadu on April 3 it was clear that the session had exposed the plethora of dilemmas dogging CPI(M) itself.

If any one message could be singled out from the six-day conclave held at the textile city, it was this: despite trying to flex its muscles by raising the bogey of a Third Alternative, CPI(M) will be more than satisfied with the status quo even after the next general elections. Never in its 40 years has the

party wielded so much power which is not quite commensurate with the support it enjoys across the country, not to speak of its parliamentary strength, which is less than a tenth of the Lok Sabha. It suits the party fine to try and continue to enjoy power without the burden of responsibility for another term. By lending critical support from the outside once again to a Congress-led coalition, it can continue to run with the hare and hunt with the hound. It can block official policies and programmes that are not to its liking and extract its pound of flesh from the